

To: Dr. Morufu Olatunji Alausa, Honourable Minister of Education, Nigeria

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Re: Uniform Policy, Unequal Access: A call to action to address the North-South divide in access to pre-tertiary education in Nigeria

Executive Summary

In Nigeria, there is the problem of a widened gap of access to education, whereby school-age children in the Northern region have less access to the Southern region. This issue plays out to undermine the right to equitable access to education, enforce human capital gap, entrench economic underdevelopment and pressure on national unity. Despite the establishment of programmes such as Universal Basic Education (UBE) programme, National Policy on Inclusive Education in Nigeria and several targeted programmes under UBE and Federal Ministry of Education, unequal regional access to education still persists. To solve the institutional voids, attention must be focused on schools infrastructure, gender empowerment and security conditions in Northern Nigeria. In light of this, the memo addresses the problem and its causes, provides evidence for argument and also recommends potential solutions that can be adapted. A uniform access to education is important for the development and progress of Nigeria and much attention should be paid to its manifestation.

Background of Study

In 2004 Nigeria enacted a law that guaranteed every child nine years of free and compulsory basic education. Twenty years on, the nation has acquired an undesirable status of the highest number of out-of-school children in the world. According to UNICEF (2024), this number is 18.3 million, and one out of five children out of school in the world is a Nigerian. That disjuncture between the promise of the policy and children's lived experience is not accidental. It is almost overlaid on a regional fault that has a long and robust history and structure.

The reasons are stratified, though there are four prominent ones. First, poverty: in low-income families of the North, children are constantly forced into labour to complement family income, which places families in an intergenerational cycle of poverty (Nwoke et al., 2024). Second, inefficient financing: the federal education budget has remained well below the UNESCO-prescribed average of 26 percent national budget and the funds that are being allocated are not being used efficiently. During the period of 2020 to 2024, N135.5 billion worth of UBEC matching grants remained inaccessible by state governments - funds that would have been used to construct classrooms and educate teachers. Third, insecurity: According to UNICEF (2024), 19 school attacks were recorded between 2022 and 2023 and this compelled 113 schools to be shut down in Borno, Adamawa, and Yobe states. Fourth, gender norms: in the North East and North West, the primary net attendance of girls is 47.7% and 47.3% respectively, which implies that over half of all girls in these areas are out of school (UNICEF, n.d.). These reasons do not work separately. The interactions between poverty, underinvestment, conflict, and cultural marginalization strengthen each other in a way that implies that the education crisis in the North is not an easy issue to resolve.

Children are the most affected people who were already the weakest in the first place and were not even able to miss a single day at school. In Nigeria, nearly 66% of the amount of out-of-school children are located in the North West and North East (UNICEF, 2024), which are also the regions with the highest rates of poverty in the country. Girls have been the sharpest hit, however the same gap cuts across displaced children, children in nomadic communities, and children in Quranic schools who have no literacy training.

This is the type of imbalance that the Universal Basic Education Commission (UBEC) introduced under the UBE Act of 2004 was meant to address. It provides states with federal matching grants to build schools, train teachers and purchase learning supplies. Ideally, it is a good mechanism. In practice it has been weakened by a structural weakness: states have to offer 50 percent counterpart funding in order to obtain federal grants and the states which are most in need are the ones which can least raise such funds. By December 2024, more than N263 billion of UBEC funds were still unclaimed, and 34 states were still not drawing their allocations

(Universal Basic Education Commission, 2024). The money exists. The schools which require it are not beneficiaries of it.

Considering such a course of action, the repercussions will reach far beyond the classroom. An uneducated youthful population in the North increases the cycle of poverty, inequalities across geographical areas, and provides the very environment of idleness and frustration that insurgent groups have traditionally used to recruit. Nigeria cannot afford to consider this a northern issue. A poor North undermines the whole nation. The policy of UBE was a pledge. It is time to ask, seriously, why it has not been kept.

Evidence and Analysis

Evidence from this memo draws on secondary data sources from statistical reports from UNICEF and UBEC. Insights were discovered based on descriptive and comparative analysis of disparity in education access in the North and South region of Nigeria. Key Indicators measured include out-of-school rates and school infrastructure metrics. Findings, however, are limited by outdated and insufficient data in recent years.

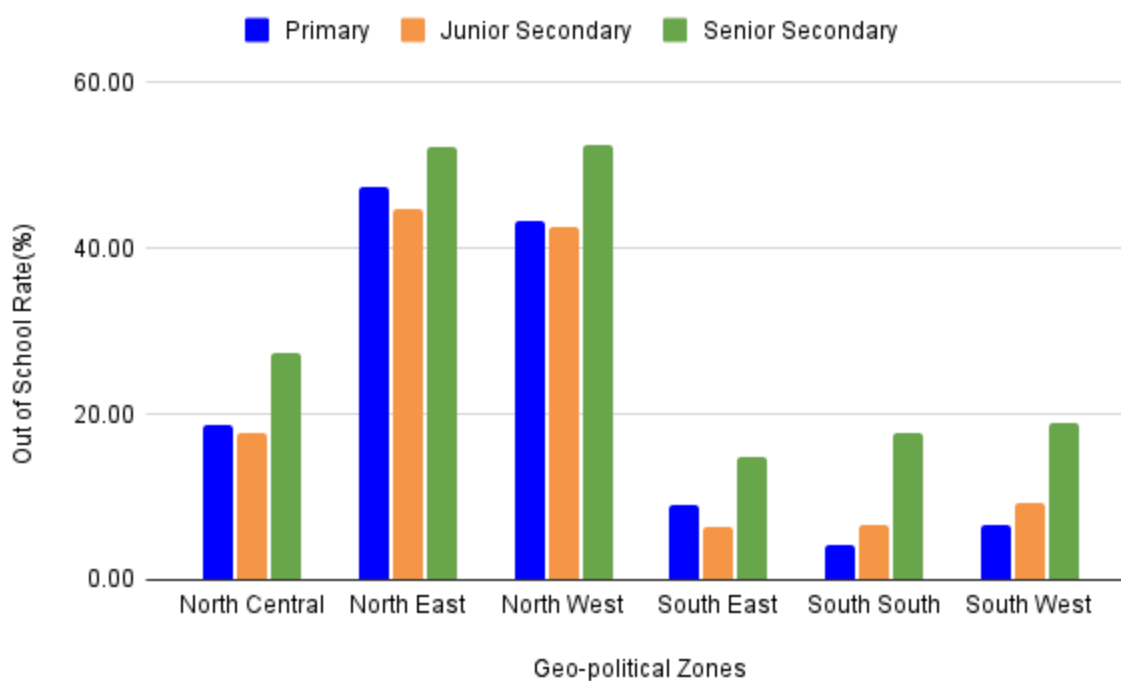


Fig 1: Nigeria out-school-rates by geopolitical zones and school levels. Note: Authors' own computation based on state-level data adapted from UNICEF(2023)

Fig 1 illustrates out-of-school rates across Nigeria's six geopolitical zones, with percentages on the y-axis and zones represented on the x-axis. The analysis shows that there is a clear regional gap, with the North zones having higher rates than the south region. North East and North West are worst among all, with both around 43-53% across all three levels. This means that one in two school aged children are not in school, either at primary and secondary levels. North Central (18-27%) appears to perform much better, but it is still low compared to the south zones. The South region, on the other hand, has a relatively low amount of children out of school across all levels. Notably, all zones have higher out-school-rates in the senior secondary level. This means that drop-outs are more likely to happen at the secondary level as it becomes harder to keep them in school.

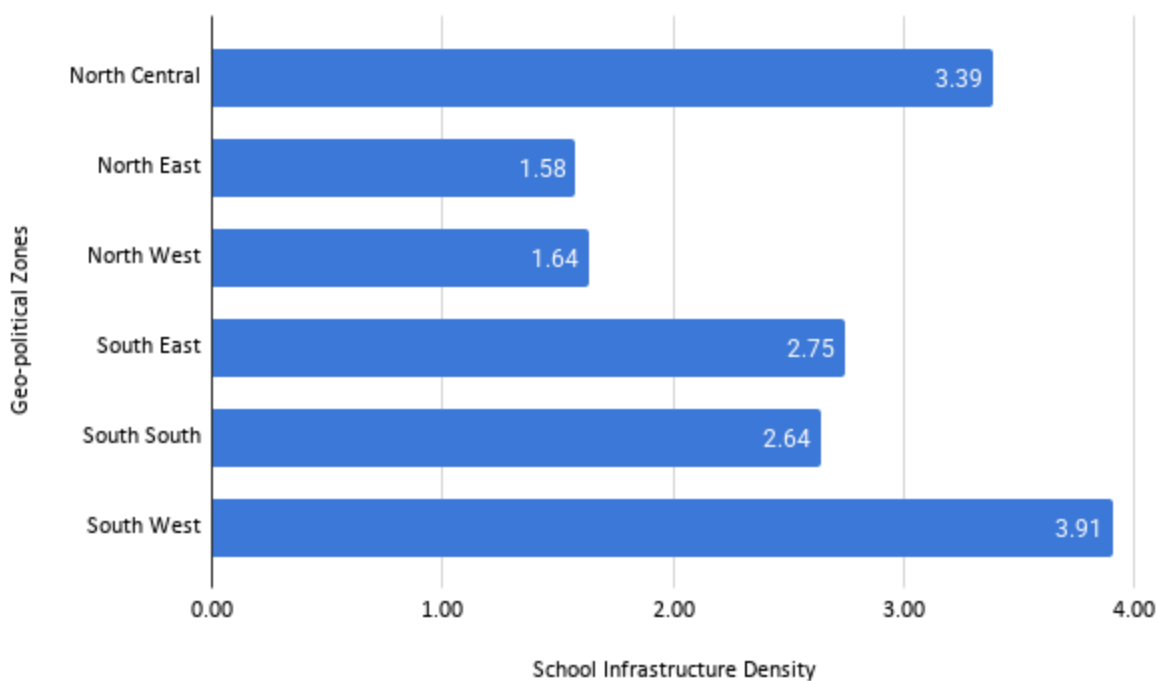


Fig 2: School infrastructure density (schools per 1,000 children), by zone. Note: Authors' own computation based on state-level data adapted from UBEC (2022).

The South regional zones (South West, South East, South South) occupy three out of the four highest infrastructure deficits, which further strengthen our argument that there is large disparity to access to education in Nigeria. North Central (3.39) is the second highest, but more surprisingly, the zone is closer to the southern region than the north. North West (1.64) and North East (1.58) clearly show low density and this indicates a high school infrastructure deficit. In essence, a child that lives in the North East has access to less than half the school infrastructure that exists in the South West region.

Proposed Recommendation and Actions

1. **Reform Funding Structure:** Many states in the North cannot access UBE intervention funds due to weak economic power. Funding is crucial ensuring young children access to education as it finances school constructions, teacher training, and learning materials. Hence, much attention should be paid to this root cause of North-South divide.

1.1 Low IGR states in the North East and North West such as Yobe, Ebonyi, Kebbi, Taraba, Adamawa, e.t.c, should be given less strict conditional rules to access intervention funds. The compulsory counterpart contribution can be reduced from 50% to 20% for these states.

1.2 The HMoE should work with UBEC to plan adjustment and lobby National Assembly for approval

1.3 The Revenue Mobilization Allocation and Fiscal Commission (RMAFC) would then create a formula that prioritises states with low IGR, high out-of-school rates and high poverty index

2. **A comprehensive research should be conducted :** There is low availability of research and data on the North-South gap to access to education in Nigeria, and other aspects of education at large. The statistical report on UBEC's website which includes data on every aspect of education implementation only contains information up to 2022 and this contributes to lack of awareness of the several anomalies in the education sector.

2.1 The Honorable Minister of Education (HMoE) should meet with UBEC and National Bureau of Statistics and discuss a plan to conduct a longitudinal data collection project. The budget should be designed to reflect the scale and scope of the projects and partnership should be secured with international organizations such as UNICEF, World Bank, and UNESCO Institute of Statistics to provide research assistance as it would be needed.

3. **Establish a programme that focuses on increasing girls and out-of-school children access** to education in the Northern regions with much focus on North East and North West states. Such programme should aim at addressing challenges that prevent them from accessing and completing pre-tertiary education.

3.1 The HMoE should be meet with UBEC officials, state ministries of education, SUBEBs, teachers and local government stakeholders in the focused Northern states to formulate an initiative that better reflect the realities of the situation

3.2 There should also be meetings with development partners such as UNICEF and the World Bank and local NGOs for funding and data support.

4. **Set up a programme that focuses on ensuring displaced children have access to education** to at least secondary level. This should target states with high internally

displaced persons (IDP) for a long period of time: Borno, Adamawa, Benue, Katsina, Zamfara and Yobe. School-aged children that are displaced due to insecurity should be given free access to education.

4.1 Displaced children should be enrolled in school free of charge, given books, pencils and other learning materials to aid their learning. Accommodation should also be provided to them and their relatives to ensure that they grow in an accommodating environment.

4.2 Students that perform exceptionally should be given scholarships to study in tertiary institutions and those that show interest in entrepreneurship or vocational skills should be provided training to develop the knowledge.

4.3 The ministry of education should partner with private institutions to ensure that public schools are not over-crowded and orphanages house in cases of absence of loved ones.

5. Work towards increase of basic education to children aged 15-18 years: From figure 1, you would see that there is a universal pattern of high rate out-of-school children in the senior secondary level across all zones. This is no coincidence: the UBE policy only focuses on education up to junior secondary level and this has led to a large number of children not continuing school after the level. Although public senior secondary schools are under the jurisdiction of the state governments, most of them rely on the Federation Account Allocation Committee (FAAC) which limits the effectiveness of the program.

5.1 The HMoE should conduct or commission an education sector review showing dropout rates at junior secondary level and transition gaps into senior secondary.

5.2. The Ministry of Education must work with the National Assembly to amend the UBEC act (2004) to include funding-support for projects at senior secondary school level. Support could be subject to criteria such as purposeful project proposals from SUBEB.

Implementation Work Timeline

S/N	Summary Overview	Timeline
1	Reform UBE funding structure	6-18 months

S/N	Summary Overview	Timeline
2	Commission Comprehensive Education Research	12- 24 months
3	Girls and Out-of-School Children Programme	12-36 months
4	Displaced Children Education Programme	6- 30 months
5	Extend UBE Coverage to Senior Level	18-48 months

Urgency Statement

Nigeria cannot create a united country with two different futures. The North-South education divide is not merely a matter of inequality anymore with more than 17 million children out of school in the country. (UNICEF, 2023). This is a national emergency. The Honourable Minister needs to take decisive actions, as every year of indecision is one year of lost generations.

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Terms

- IDP - Internally Displaced Persons

- IGR - Internally Generated Revenue
- Pre-tertiary education: includes early child education, primary education, junior secondary education and senior secondary education
- UBE - Universal Basic Education
- UBEC- Universal Basic Education Commission
- UNESCO - United Nations Educational, Scientific, and Cultural Organisation
- UNICEF- United Nations Children's Fund
- SUBEC- State Universal Basic Education Commission
- North Central States: Benue, Kogi, Kwara, Nasarrawa, Niger, Plateau, FCT
- North East States: Adamawa, Bauchi, Borno, Gombe, Taraba, Yobe
- North West States : Jigawa, Kaduna, Kano, Katsina, Kebbi, Sokoto, Zamfara
- South East States: Abia, Anambra, Ebonyi, Enugu, Imo
- South West States: Ekiti, Lagos, Ogun, Ondo, Osun, Oyo
- South South States: Akwa Ibom, Bayelsa, Cross River, Delta, Edo, Rivers